

1 Thessalonians, Part 1

The gospel received under pressure

BIG IDEA The gospel creates a faithful community whose changed life becomes a witness even under pressure.

Purpose and outcome

By the end of the lesson, the class should be able to:

- describe how the gospel reached Thessalonica amid opposition and why “three Sabbaths” does not necessarily define the missionaries’ entire stay;
- identify the visible marks of Thessalonian faith: work produced by faith, labor prompted by love, endurance inspired by hope, changed allegiance, and outward witness;
- explain how Paul’s conduct supported his message and answered charges of greed, manipulation, and self-interest;
- recognize persecution as pressure that tests faith without concluding that hardship means the gospel has failed; and
- show how the Holy Spirit forms a church whose faith, love, hope, and witness become visible to others.

Lesson at a glance

TIME	MOVEMENT
0:00–4:00	Opening prayer and bridge from Galatians
4:00–11:00	Gospel arrives under pressure — Acts 17:1–10
11:00–23:00	What visible faith looks like — 1 Thessalonians 1
23:00–34:00	The character of gospel ministry — 1 Thessalonians 2:1–12
34:00–41:00	Receiving the Word and enduring opposition — 2:13–3:10
41:00–45:00	Paul’s prayer for love and holiness — 3:11–13
45:00–48:00	The Gospel Then and Now
48:00–50:00	Summary, Lesson 7 reading, and prayer

Before class

Write on the board: “What makes a church’s faith in Christ visible?” Have Acts 17:1–10; 1 Thessalonians 1:2–10; 2:1–12; 2:17–3:10; and 3:11–13 marked. Use one reader and participants’ own Bibles or apps. The lesson is self-contained for those who did not complete the reading.

CORE READINGS Acts 17:1–10; 1 Thessalonians 1:2–10; 2:1–12; 3:6–13. Summarize 2:13–3:5 if time is short.

1. CORE — The gospel enters Thessalonica

Use Acts 17:1–10 to locate the letter. Paul, Silas, and their companions reached Thessalonica after suffering in Philippi. The journey west along the Via Egnatia was roughly one hundred miles. Paul reasoned in the synagogue for three Sabbaths, explaining from Scripture that the Messiah had to suffer and rise and announcing that Jesus is that Messiah.

- Three Sabbaths describes the synagogue ministry Luke highlights; it does not prove the missionaries remained in the city only three weeks. The letter and Philippians 4:15–16 may suggest a somewhat longer stay.
- Acts names some Jewish believers, many God-fearing Greeks, and prominent women. First Thessalonians 1:9 also points to converts who had worshiped idols.
- Some Jewish opponents recruited troublemakers, stirred a crowd, and accused the missionaries of defying Caesar by proclaiming another king, Jesus. Avoid speaking as though all Jews opposed Paul.
- Jason and the young church bore the risk after the missionaries left. From its beginning, this congregation learned that allegiance to Jesus could carry social and political cost.

TEACHING LINE The gospel did not enter Thessalonica under ideal conditions. It took root while the messengers and hearers were under pressure.

2. CORE — Faith made visible

Read 1 Thessalonians 1:2–10. Paul does not begin with the church's building, budget, influence, or comfort. He thanks God for evidence that the gospel has taken root.

- Faith works, love labors, and hope endures (1:3). These deeds do not earn salvation; they are the visible fruit of God's saving work.
- Paul recognizes God's choosing grace through the gospel's arrival in power, the Holy Spirit, deep conviction, and the changed lives of both messengers and hearers (1:4–6). This supports ECO Essential Tenet III.B: election is for salvation and service.
- The movement is receive, imitate, become a model, and resound. A young church under pressure becomes an example beyond Macedonia and Achaia (1:6–8).
- Their conversion has direction: they turned from idols, serve the living and true God, and wait for his Son from heaven (1:9–10). Christian hope produces present allegiance and service.

LOOK CLOSER “Rang out” translates *exēcheomai*, the only New Testament occurrence of this verb. It means to sound forth, echo, or resound. Paul pictures both the Lord's message and the report of their faith carrying far beyond the city.

3. CORE — A message supported by a life

Read 1 Thessalonians 2:1–12. Traveling teachers could seek money, admiration, or influence. Paul answers accusations about his motives by reminding the church of conduct they personally witnessed.

- His appeal did not spring from error, impure motives, trickery, flattery, concealed greed, or a desire for human praise (2:3–6).
- Paul and his coworkers shared the gospel and their own lives. He uses the tender images of a nursing mother and a father who encourages, comforts, and urges (2:7–12).
- They worked “night and day” to avoid burdening the church (2:9). Acts 18:3 identifies Paul's trade as tentmaking in Corinth; it is reasonable, but not explicit, that he practiced the same trade here.
- Paul also received support from Philippi (Philippians 4:15–16). His integrity was not isolation from all support; it was freedom from greed and from exploiting converts as customers.

GUARDRAIL Do not make unpaid ministry the only faithful model. Paul could work with his hands, accept missionary partnership, and teach that gospel workers may receive support. The issue here is motive and conduct, not a universal ban on compensation.

4. CORE — The Word at work under pressure

Summarize 2:13–3:5, then read 3:6–13. The Thessalonians received the apostolic message as God's Word, and that Word remained at work in them while they suffered. Paul's forced separation did not produce indifference. He longed to return and repeatedly tried.

- In 2:14–16 Paul speaks about particular opponents who persecuted Judean Christians and obstructed the Gentile mission. This text cannot support hostility toward Jewish people; Paul, Jesus, the apostles, and the Judean churches were Jewish.
- “Satan blocked our way” (2:18) describes real spiritual opposition. The verb *enkoptō* can picture cutting into or blocking a road. Paul does not identify the earthly mechanism, so the teacher should not invent one.
- When Paul could not return, he sent Timothy to strengthen and encourage the believers. Gospel ministry adapts without surrendering its purpose.
- Timothy's report was encouraging, not a claim that everything was complete. Their faith and love remained, yet Paul still wanted to “supply what is lacking” in their faith (3:10).
- Paul's prayer asks God to reopen the road, increase their love, strengthen their hearts, and make them holy as they await Christ (3:11–13). This prepares the class for chapters 4–5.

TEACHING LINE Satan blocked Paul's road, but he did not silence the gospel. Paul sent Timothy, prayed continually, and wrote a letter that still strengthens churches.

The Gospel Then and Now

MOVEMENT	CHURCH APPLICATION
Church reality then	A young church faced public pressure, questioned leaders, separation from its founders, and uncertainty about whether it could endure.
Church temptation now	We can measure health by facilities, finances, attendance, reputation, programs, comfort, or preferred demographics while overlooking faith, love, hope, holiness, and witness.
Gospel-shaped church	The gospel arrives in the Spirit's power, produces credible lives and steadfast love, and resounds through a congregation that serves and waits for Christ together.

Discussion

1. What makes a church's faith in Christ visible?
2. Which common signs of church health are easiest to confuse with gospel faithfulness?
3. How did Paul's conduct support rather than contradict his message?
4. Why do suffering and joy appear together in 1:6?
5. What does Paul's response to being blocked teach us about gospel ministry?
6. What would it mean for the Lord's message to "ring out" from our congregation?

Scholarly notes and guardrails

- Length of the stay — Do not equate three synagogue Sabbaths with the entire Thessalonian mission. State the minimum Luke gives and leave the full duration open.
- Later synagogue tradition — A later tradition associated Thessalonica's Etz Achaim synagogue, destroyed in the 1917 fire, with Paul's preaching. This cannot establish that it was the same first-century building or site; omit unless asked.
- "Rang out" — Exēcheomai emphasizes sound spreading or echoing. Use thunder as an illustrative comparison only, not as the verb's fixed definition.
- Satan's hindrance — Treat spiritual opposition seriously without guessing at a political, legal, medical, or logistical mechanism Paul does not name.
- Persecution language — Keep Paul's criticism historically specific. It must never become a general indictment of Jewish people.
- Election — Paul knows the Thessalonians are loved and chosen because the Spirit-empowered gospel produced conviction, imitation, perseverance, and witness. Avoid turning the paragraph into a detached debate over the mechanics of election.

Leader preparation

Commentary and further study: John Stott, *The Message of 1 & 2 Thessalonians*; Michael W. Holmes, *1 and 2 Thessalonians* (NIV Application Commentary); D. Michael Martin, *1, 2 Thessalonians* (New American Commentary); Craig S. Keener, *The IVP Bible Background Commentary: New Testament*; John B. Polhill, *Acts* (New American Commentary).

Online resource: BibleProject, *Book of 1 Thessalonians Guide* — bibleproject.com/guides/book-of-1-thessalonians/

ECO connection: Essential Tenet III.B (election for salvation and service) and III.C (covenant life in the church). Official text: eco-pres.org/constitution/

Before Lesson 7: Start with 1 Thessalonians 4:1–18 and 5:1–11. If possible, finish chapter 5. Notice how believers live, grieve, wait, and encourage one another in hope.

LIKELY RABBIT TRAILS The exact length of Paul's stay, the later synagogue tradition, tentmaking versus paid ministry, identifying Satan's method, and arguments about the timing of Christ's return. Answer briefly, name what the text does not say, and return to visible faith under pressure.